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Musical instruments (generic)

7.1 Musical instruments (generic)

References:

Hebrew כְּלִי (kli) 1CH 16:5, 1CH 23:5, PSA 71:22

Hebrew כְּלִי (kle david) 2CH 29:26, 2CH 29:27

Hebrew כְּלִי, עֹז (kle ‘oz) 2CH 30:21

Hebrew כְּלִי, שִׁיר (kle shir) 1CH 15:16, 1CH 16:42, 2CH 5:13, 2CH 7:6, 2CH 23:13, 2CH 34:12, NEH 12:36, AMO 6:5

Hebrew מֵן (men) PSA 45:9, PSA 150:4

Description:

The terms listed above refer to musical instruments collectively.

Translation:

The Hebrew expression kle david in 2CH 29:26; 2CH 29:27 associates certain musical instruments with King David. Some translations retain the ambiguity of the Hebrew with “instruments of David” (RSV, REB, NJPSV). CEV has “instruments that belonged to David,” while GNT “instruments like those that King David had used” does not assume that David’s own instruments were still in working condition after three hundred years.

In 2CH 30:21 the Hebrew expression kle ‘oz has been understood in various ways. Some take it to refer to instruments (NJPSV “powerful instruments,” CEV “instruments”; compare NCV “loud music”). Others take the phrase to describe the atmosphere of praise (REB “unrestrained fervour,” GNT “all their strength”). This latter interpretation is based on a minor emendation of the text to make it agree with 1CH 13:8, but HOTTP does not recommend it.

PSA 150:3; PSA 150:4; PSA 150:5 lists several musical instruments. The trumpets were played by the priests; the Levites played the harps, lyres, and cymbals; and the other instruments (verse 4) were played by lay people. In verse 4 the Hebrew word men probably refers to “stringed instruments.” The translation of the Hebrew terms for these musical instruments is usually handled in one of three ways: (a) by using descriptive phrases; (b) by using local instruments; or (c) by using generic terms accompanied by a loan word. An illustration of the first way would be to translate “cymbals” as “flat metal plates that were struck together.” An example of the third way would be to render the same word as “percussion instruments called cymbals.”

In DAN 3:5; DAN 3:7; DAN 3:10; DAN 3:15, the writer gives a list of six different musical instruments. In many languages where such instruments are not well known, this poses serious translation problems. If it proves impossible to have the same number of instruments as in the biblical text, the number may be reduced (in some manuscripts there are only five names here); however, lists are an important characteristic of the book of Daniel, and it is recommended that a list of instruments be maintained here and not replaced by a summary expression, such as “the band” in LB.